PRESS RELEASE | FINANCIAL SUPERVISION

National Bank maintains recently adjusted macroprudential policy

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In its press release of 7 November 2025, the National Bank of Belgium (NBB) announced an adjustment to its macroprudential policy in 2026. Owing to reduced vulnerabilities in mortgage loan portfolios, a halving of the macroprudential capital buffer for risks in Belgian mortgage portfolios was deemed justified. In order to simplify its macroprudential policy and ensure that it is as effective as possible, the NBB further decided to no longer impose a separate buffer for mortgage loans and to incorporate this requirement into the countercyclical capital buffer (CCyB).

This decision led to a raising of the countercyclical capital buffer from 1% to 1.25% on 1 January 2026. This increase will take effect on 1 July 2026, following a six-month transition period. The amount of the buffer will thereby increase from approximately €2.7 billion to around €3.3 billion. At the same time, the specific capital buffer for risks in mortgage portfolios, which currently amounts to approximately €1.3 billion, will be abolished. From 1 July 2026, the macroprudential capital requirements will thus be both simplified and reduced, falling from approximately €3.9 billion to €3.3 billion. The reduction in these total requirements corresponds to the decrease in risks in mortgage portfolios.

The NBB is required by law to review the level of the countercyclical capital buffer every quarter. This is a temporary additional capital reserve that increases the resilience of banks, so that they can better absorb credit losses and continue to support borrowers in the event of a sharp increase in repayment difficulties. The NBB has decided to maintain the rate of this capital buffer at 1.25% for the second quarter of 2026.

The NBB will continue to adjust the level of this countercyclical capital buffer going forward based on developments in the credit and financial cycle, which are currently pointing upwards. After a slowdown due to the sharp rise in interest rates, which, however, proceeded in a very orderly manner, both lending to the real economy and the residential property market in Belgium recovered reasonably swiftly and are currently back to dynamic levels again. Monetary policy has also been eased, giving an additional boost to lending. In addition, there have been substantial stock market gains in recent quarters while risk premia on the bond markets remained historically low. However, military conflict in the Middle East and investor anxiety about the massive investments being made in artificial intelligence and the potentially disruptive effects of this technology on certain sectors have led to increased financial market volatility in recent weeks. The NBB will monitor these developments closely. For the time being, it considers that a countercyclical capital buffer of 1.25% is so far sufficient to ensure the resilience of the Belgian banking sector. The Belgian financial sector has, in the meantime, maintained its strong financial position.

Belgian banks are the largest providers by far of external debt financing to Belgian households and Belgian non-financial corporations, with outstanding loans to these sectors amounting to €308 billion and €191 billion, respectively. Should Belgian banks unexpectedly face a significant increase in repayment difficulties in specific segments of their loan portfolios, the accumulated countercyclical capital buffer can be (partly) released. This would help banks absorb the shock in an orderly manner and support affected borrowers.

2026 Q2: Quarterly decision of the National Bank of Belgium on the countercyclical buffer rate (1 April 2026): 1.25 %